

Silent letters

A SILENT LETTER IS WRITTEN BUT NOT PRONOUNCED.

English includes many words with silent letters. This can sometimes make spelling difficult; however, learning to recognize certain patterns can help with spelling these words.

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Silent letters

Letters that do not affect the sound of a word are called silent letters. In many cases, these letters were once clearly heard, but over time the pronunciation of the words has changed, even though the spelling has stayed the same.

condemn

If the silent *n* is removed, it does not change the sound of this word—but it would be misspelled.

Letter	When it can be silent	Examples
a	before or after another vowel	aisle, cocoa, head
b	after <i>m</i> before <i>t</i>	crumb, limb, thumb debt, doubt, subtle
c	after <i>s</i>	muscle, scent, scissors
d	before or after <i>n</i>	Wednesday, handsome, landscape
e	at the end of a word	giraffe, humble, love
g	before <i>h</i> before <i>n</i>	daughter, though, weigh campaign, foreign, gnome
h	at the beginning of a word after <i>ex</i> after <i>g</i> after <i>r</i> after <i>w</i>	heir, honest, hour exhausting, exhibition, exhilarate ghastly, ghost, ghoul rhapsody, rhinoceros, rhyme whale, wheel, whirlpool
k	before <i>n</i>	knee, knight, know
l	before <i>d</i> before <i>f</i> before <i>m</i>	could, should, would behalf, calf, half almond, calm, palm
n	after <i>m</i>	autumn, hymn, solemn
p	before <i>n</i> before <i>s</i> before <i>t</i>	pneumatic, pneumonia, pneumatic psalm, psychiatry, psychic pteranodon, pterodactyl, receipt
t	before <i>ch</i> after <i>s</i>	catch, stretch, witch castle, Christmas, listen
u	with other vowels	building, court, guess
w	before <i>r</i> with <i>s</i> or <i>t</i>	wreck, write, wrong answer, sword, two